“good friends,” Khurshid explained, “despite the fact that we [India] could not stand by them [Iran] in critical moments when it came to voting in the United Nations.” “We have had to take positions [in the U.N.] that obviously [do] not necessarily align themselves with the aspirations or at least perceived aspirations of Iran in recent times.” “Anyone is disappointed if you cannot get someone to stand by you in moments which are critical,” Khurshid explained. India had voted in favour of US-backed UN resolutions calling for Iran to address international concerns about its nuclear programmes. India and Iran had had “very critical and crucial discussions and dialogue” about the need for Iran to address the concerns of the international community. The “good news” was that Iran has understood this and “We have remained … good friends with Iran.”

As part of India’s courtship of post-JCPOA Iran, New Delhi laid out for Tehran why India’s strategic partnership with the United States should not adversely affect India–Iran ties. Washington was, of course, Tehran’s nemesis, while India had emerged as Washington’s important partner. China’s representatives in Tehran would not miss the opportunity to insinuate, one way or another, that New Delhi’s close relation with Washington made India a less reliable partner than China. When Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei met Xi Jinping during the latter’s January 2016 visit to Tehran, Khamenei pledged Iran’s loyalty to China, saying: “Iran is the most reliable country in the region for energy since its energy policies will never be affected by foreigners.”[27]

Regarding India’s strategic partnership with the United States, Khurshid underscored that “we have a strategic partnership with the United States of America” which was “very valuable and important” for India. But, while India remained “good friends” with the United States of America, it was simultaneously “*extremely* good friends with Iran” (emphasis added). In fact, India’s link with the United States